Appendix 3

Headlines after my taking over as army chief



I'm first and last an Indian, says JJ

Vishal Thapar
New Delhi, November 27

LIEUTENANT-GENERAL Joginder Jaswant Singh was on Saturday declared the next Chief of Army Staff. He will take over from General N.C. Vij.

Singh, presently the general officer commanding-in-chief of the Western Command, will take over as the 14th chief of the Indian Army on February 1, 2005. He will have a two-year and 10-month tenure at the top slot. While the government has gone by the convention of seniority in naming Singh, Chief-designate, he will, incidentally, also be the first Sikh to hold the post.

Singh himself played down the circumstances. "I consider myself first and last an Indian," he told the *Hindustan Times*.

The General-designate is a third generation military officer. His grandfather and father are veterans of World War-I and II respectively. Widely perceived to be a thinking general, Singh is the architect of the Indian Army Doctrine, which has recently been made public.

An infantryman, Singh will also be the first Army Chief with hands-on experience in combating insurgency in Jammu and Kashmir. He was seriously wounded while leading troops from the front in a counter-terrorist operation in the Kashmir Valley while commanding a brigade.

The Chief-designate is supportive of the troop reduction initiative in Jammu and Kashmir. "The decision is based on sound fundamentals. The manpower reduction will not (adversely) affect the operational situation, both along the Line of Control and the interior areas," he said.

Describing the move as a "step in the right direction" and one "in consonance with the confidence-building measures", Singh said the troop reduction would be reviewed after monitoring the ground situation.

He strongly defended the human rights record of the Indian Army describing the Manorama Devi incident in Manipur as an aberration. "We belong to the country and are with the people," he stressed, maintaining that the Army's human rights record can compare favourably with other armies in similar situations.

Singh has an impressive command profile. He was the commander of 1 Corps, the Indian Army's main strike formation, during the 10-month long eyeball-to-eyeball confrontation with Pakistan in 2001-2002. During the Kargil conflict, he was the public face of the Indian Army as its Additional Director-General, Military Operations. He was commissioned in the Maratha Light Infantry regiment.

PROUD MOMENT: Lt Gen J.J. Singh and his wife in New Delhi on Saturday after hearing of his appointment as the next Army Chief.

Sikh 'jinx' broken with appointment

Kanwar Sandhu
Chandigarh, November 27

IN ANNOUNCING Lt-Gen J.J. Singh appointment as the next Chief of Army Staff, the government has not only upheld the seniority principle but also broken the 'jinx' of the top military slot eluding Sikh officers.

With Singh's appointment, the government has set to rest reports of the elevation of current incumbent Gen N.C. Vij as Chief of Defence Staff (when his superannuation, which could have put Singh out of the reckoning for the Army Chief's post.

The seniority principle has generally been upheld, except on a few occasions. However, it is the breaking of the Sikh 'jinx' that is the talking point today. While two Sikh officers have made it to the top in the IAF, the Army hasn't had a Sikh chief despite a very large presence of the community. The last Sikh officer to come near enough was Lt-Gen Surjit Singh, former GOC-in-C of the Western Command. But a two-year extension in service across the board put him out of the running.

However, many retired officers look at Singh's elevation in purely professional terms, Says Sangey, "I shouldn't be viewed in parochial terms. By upholding the seniority principle, the government has given Lt-Gen Singh his due. His career profile bears it out".



No more 'kills', orders JJ

Vishal Thapar
New Delhi, February 1

IN HIS first directive to the Army as its new Chief, General J.J. Singh has removed the hackles terminology from operations against militants.

"The use of the word 'kills' has been forbidden. The word is out of bounds for the Army in its communications," General Singh declared in his first public statement after assuming charge as the 24th Chief of the Indian Army. "After all, we are talking of our own boys," he reasoned, while refusing to elaborate.

The move is prompted by the General's desire to attempt an image correction and project his force as a genuine people's army. It is expected to have a significant impact on the way the military conducts operations against rebels.

Performance of Army units deployed in counter-insurgency operations has so far been evaluated mainly on the basis of 'kills and captures'. Unit citations — which are the equivalent of 'battle honours' — and gallantry medals too are awarded on the basis of this numbers game.

General Singh has now read out the cursor 'Kills' will no longer be the primary determinant in assessing performance. Image and goodwill, along with effectiveness, will be the determining criteria. And ordinary citizens will have a say in the matter.

"We will start eliciting feedback about the functioning of Army units from the people living in the area where these are deployed. The district administration and police will be involved in this exercise. Awards will be given to units which have earned a good image while producing results rather than those which have notched up more kills but eroded the will to the people," the Army Chief said.

The earlier head-hunting approach had the inherent risk of excesses being committed, and the Army had come under criticism on this count.

The new Army leadership has some clear ideas on how to ensure combination without causing offence to innocents. One is the use of minimum force. Another is to keep a friendlier profile.

"Conduct of troops is important... Even the way they hold their guns can make a difference. We'll get special slings to ensure that the guns are pointed down so that they don't look threatening," the General said. Officers must also be gentlemen.

↓ The use of the word 'kills' has been forbidden... After all, we are talking of our own boys ↑
—General J.J. Singh



The 'humane face' of Army

By Rajat Pandit/TNN

New Delhi: "It's better that 10 guilty persons escape than one innocent suffer," said Lance Naik Gulabkhan in the 19th Century. Taking a cue from this legal aphorism, the Army's new mantra will now be: "Don't harm an innocent even if a terrorist escapes."

Or so, new Army chief General Joginder Jaswant Singh promised on Tuesday. His new blueprint for the 1.10-million strong Army is "one of minimum force", with "minimum collateral damage", while battling militants in Kashmir as well as the North-East.

"Despite adverse conditions, the Army will prevail a much more humane face since we are, after all, dealing with misguided youth of our own country," said Gen Singh, recalling his own days in J&K as a brigade commander when he was even wounded in anti-terrorist operations. "Even while being prolific and non-apologetic, the Army can be unequivocally offensive and firm," he said. As a "practical example", soldiers will be taught to point their guns downwards while talking to people, and not even threaten them.

Towards this refined new approach to "win hearts and minds" in a sensitive manner, battalions will no longer be judged by the number of militants they kill. This policy effort led to iron-fisted measures. Instead, the Army will now reward battalions that exhibit "good behaviour and conduct", based on civilian "feedback" from their operational area.

Battalions, in fact, are being told to delete the word "militant kills" from their citations. The Army will also upgrade its Operation Sadbhavana, the development and welfare measure, to J&K since 1990. Lending the confidence-building measures with Pakistan, including the ceasefire which was holding despite a couple of stray incidents, he said the Army would "do its bit" to help in bringing reapprochement, "without lowering our guard" or "diluting our fight against terrorism". Asked about the recurring indiscipline and, on rare cases, Gen Singh said a "few aberrations" in such a large force were an cause for worry.

"Moreover, we do not condone mistakes in the Army. Prompt disciplinary action is taken. Introspection is done to minimise such incidents," he said. He said the main thrust would be to keep the Army in a state of "operational readiness", along with its rapid modernisation into a high-tech force capable of operating effectively with the Navy and IAF across the entire spectrum of conflict.

Army chief Gen JJ Singh arrives at South Block on Tuesday.

Stay fit, not fat, says new chief

New Delhi: For Skilled Colonels, Brigadiers and Generals, better watch out. JJ is now on the prowl to check the while if your body mass index doesn't quite add up.

New Army chief Gen J J Singh on Tuesday said he would place a "lot of emphasis" on physical fitness and sports in the 1.15-million strong force. If 40-year-old Paula Singh could run The London Marathon, senior officers cannot shirk fitness. "I would like to lead by example," said the chief.

Gen Singh, 58, has been a keen mountaineer and boxer in his younger days. "Even today, he loves to believe in shooting and golf. He is also plays tennis quite a bit," said a fellow Jaipur officer.

Army mantra: Kill is dead, long live skill

By GAUTAM DATT

New Delhi, Feb. 1: Indian Army soldiers will now point their guns downward and drop the word "kills" from their vocabulary, as the force attempts to win the hearts and minds of people in states afflicted by insurgency.

On his first day in office, the new Chief of Army Staff, Gen. J.J. Singh, announced a series of measures to project the Army's "human face" in dealing with sensitive situations in Jammu and Kashmir and the Northeast.

After inspecting a guard of honour outside his South Block office here, Gen. Singh said that he objects to the word "kills" used frequently in Army parlance for terrorist casualties. He said that not only would the word be dropped, units would be judged on the basis of feedback from local populations about their behaviour and not the number of "kills."

SPOTLIGHT



Gen. J.J. Singh, Army Chief

He said soldiers would now be asked to hold their guns downwards and not in a manner to intimidate citizens. This, said the Army chief, would be made possible by providing new slings enabling the guns to be carried facing downward without hampering their use in the event of an emergency.

The general said a new armed forces joint doctrine was in the pipeline. Even the new war doctrine of the Army would be finetuned and put to the test through exercises. Referring to recent incidents of indiscipline, he said such instances were minuscule. "We do not condone such mistakes. Prompt and stern disciplinary action

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